

Write to the Editor

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Digit will publish the best letters on these pages. Letters may be edited for clarity. You must include your complete address in all communication.

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LETTERS OF THE MONTH

late, and to tell you the truth, the perfect solution to this still eludes us. We have always been at the mercy of couriers. With the rains causing even more problems, June, July, and August have always been the worst months for us.

With newsstand copies, we hand them over to distributors all over India, who then send it to all the newsstand dealers and booksellers. Their network is so organised, and competition between them so strong, that almost all newsstand dealers pick up their copies personally from distributors. There are even fights over who gets delivery first! Added to this is the fact that they don't have to hunt for addresses, and deliver multiple copies to one location, and you can see why it's that much faster. We've changed couriers several times, and found that even the largest companies just cannot compete with the aggressiveness and efficiency of our newsstand distribution network. We're still looking for a way to at least match them, if not beat them. We'll try and minimise the time difference between newsstand and subscriber copies reaching their destinations, though.

— Executive Editor

Missing The Mac

I was a keen *Digit* reader for many years, until job changes meant that I couldn't keep up the habit for the last couple of years. I am from a non-IT background (I'm a CA + MBA), but was very popular whenever any computer glitches came up, which I attribute to my large collection of *Digit* magazines, CDs and DVDs.

I have been in London for quite some time now and will be returning to India next month. I want to share my apprehensions about picking up another copy of *Digit*. This is because in my years here in London, I have discovered Mac OS X. I had heard about it being mentioned in your magazine, but having used a Mac, I can say that it has a feel and use completely unrivalled by Windows. I am in touch with a lot of people in India, and see that the Mac is catching on there. I was wondering if you, at *Digit*, are also on the bandwagon and provide information for the Mac user.

If the Mac is not well fairly represented, I would like to be another, if not the first, person to ask you to include more information on the Mac in your magazine.

Rajat Sharma

Dear Rajat,
We will be the first to admit that we haven't really covered the Mac platform in *Digit*, and

that is mainly because of a lack of demand for such content. We have also noticed the number of people with Macs grow, and with Intel getting into Macs, and ways and means of making the Mac OS run on PCs and vice versa (although not exactly legal) coming out, we will be looking at an article or two on this topic on a more regular basis. For now, we're starting to include Mac-related software on our DVD and CD. Let's hope the demand increases, and gives us an excuse to cover the platform in more depth.

— Executive Editor

Hurrah For Open Source

Thanks for the fabulous magazines and *Fast Tracks*, I am a proud *Digit* subscriber. I have a question. Recently, the Lucknow Municipal Corporation decided to switch over to open source software from the earlier Windows-based software. They say the licensing fees and cost of software prompted this decision—they reportedly spent Rs 19 lakh only on software this year. Thus my question: Why is everybody not doing the same? Are Windows and closed source software worth that price? Look at me—even after buying original Windows XP Pro, I spend a third of my bandwidth on automatic updates, with an infinite number of patches to download all the time. Shouldn't all of us give Linux a try?

Udayan

Dear Udayan,
The problem that open source software and operating systems face is acceptance. There are misconceptions about the security of open source, the services offered, etc. However, it must be said that closed source software developers reportedly provide prompt customer support, which is essential for large companies. For home users, however, this should not make a difference, and the reason for lack of implementation in homes is the learning curve, or unlearning curve—you'll have to stop thinking of computer usage in the way Windows works, and learn how Linux and other OSes work before you can reach the same comfort levels. With the level of piracy in India, people generally choose closed source software because of the familiarity, and the fact that it comes to them "free" anyway! Stricter punishments for piracy will surely see the penetration of open source increase.

— Executive Editor

Pay, Don't Pirate

Most of us Indians are pirates, and some of us are tomorrow's potential customers. But the buying options are not available widely in India. Most of us Indians don't have access to credit cards or PayPal accounts, and can only buy products via demand draft or cheque. *Digit* can easily solve this problem by selling the most common software such as Windows XP, Norton Antivirus, Microsoft Office, etc. You can also create income or commission from the software vendors by acting as their distributors or retailers. People like me will definitely buy software from you. It will also help in decreasing piracy. Surely a person who subscribes to *Digit* for a year or more can easily buy full versions of software.

Amandeep Singh

I read the two letters related to piracy in the July issue. Though the opinions were quite influential, I feel it's better to use open source or free software rather than using keygens and cracks and pirated CDs. The fact is, one doesn't know how effective the paid software is (for example, a crippled spyware remover) until you pay for it. And who knows, you might have already been fooled by the interactive interface of the software and the list of spyware shown by it in order to make you pay for it. I have been using Spybot S&D for around a year, and have found it to be the best, even better than Spyware doctor. OpenOffice.org is almost a twin of Microsoft Office; Opera and Firefox are better than Internet Explorer, and free. Quick Heal, Avast, AVG, etc., are better than some paid anti-virus software.

The point I am trying to make is that open source or free software are as good (if not better) as the paid ones. The only difference is, you need to search for them on the Net or on the *Digit* CD and DVD. Still, if people prefer unlocking crippled-software through keygens and cracks and live with the guilt of doing something illegal, that's their choice.

Kumar Pratik Patna